

POLICY PLAYBOOK

North East Scotland Creative Industries Strategy

Five costed, sequenced and accountable recommendations

How to use this document

This Policy Playbook translates the five strategic recommendations of the main report into a programme management instrument. Each recommendation is presented with:

- The specific actions required (not just the intent)
- The lead body and delivery partners
- A costed range broken down by year
- A delivery timeline in 6–12–24-month bands
- Measurable KPIs against which progress can be reported
- Key risks and dependencies that could delay or prevent delivery

The Playbook is designed to be extracted from the main report and used as a standalone working document by the Joint Cultural and Creative Economy Board (Recommendation 2), by programme officers in both local authorities, and by Creative Scotland and Scottish Enterprise in their supporting roles. It is also the submission artefact requested by Scottish Government as evidence of a costed, actionable plan. The options appraisal underlying the selection of these five recommendations, including the pathways considered and set aside, is set out in Appendix D of the main report.

Recommendations are sequenced by strategic priority.

- Recommendation 1 (CoSTAR bid) carries the firmest external deadline (the June 2026 Innovate UK call confirmation) and active bid preparation is required now.
- Recommendation 4 (Creative Ecology Structural Fund) has the most urgent delivery window: some connective organisations are at immediate risk of dissolution and the window for intervention is measured in months, not years.
- Recommendation 2 (governance) is the enabling condition for the others to function as a coherent programme.

Master delivery sequence

The table below shows the delivery timeline for all five recommendations across a four-year implementation horizon. Shading indicates when each recommendation is in active delivery.

Table 1 Master delivery sequence

Recommendation	Months 1–6	Months 7–12	Year 2	Years 3–4	Cost range / yr
R1 – CoSTAR bid	Partnership agreement in place; Phase 1 network mapping	Full bid submitted post-June 2026 confirmation	If successful: first convergence firms enrolled in programme	Aberdeen–Dundee Corridor active; CPD cohorts running	£50–75k prep; up to £5m award
R2 – Joint Board	Officer post advertised; Joint Board terms of reference agreed	Board operational; first joint application in preparation	Joint annual report published; RES creative economy chapter adopted	Joint Board the normal route for all creative economy strategy	£100–160k
R3 – Energy transition	Narrative strand deployed; ONE relationship formalised	Creative Career Bridge pilot cohort launched	JTF application submitted; Energy Transition Pathways pilot active	≥10 mid-career workers placed; NES Creative Economy Narrative formally adopted by Joint Board and cited in at least one national strategy or funding submission	£200–400k (largely JTF-fundable)
R4 – Creative Ecology Fund	First bridge grants awarded to peer infrastructure, design engagement, rural provision and early-stage convergence pipeline bodies; award decisions confirmed by Month 6	Six-monthly review; onboard new eligible organisations	≥2 orgs applying to Creative Scotland Development Fund	Emergent formation institutionally secure; churn cycle broken	£250–500k
R5 – Culture Data Hub	Codify methodology; procure DataCity licence	First corrected annual report published	Annual cycle embedded in ACC economic reporting	Sector intelligence feeding CoSTAR/JTF bids	£100k yr1; £60–80k ongoing

Recommendation 1: Advance a joint CoSTAR bid

Strategy 1: Connect complementary capabilities commercially

Aberdeen–Dundee Creative Technology Corridor: positioning Aberdeen's simulation surplus for UKRI cluster investment

Rationale and opportunity

UKRI's CoSTAR (Convergent screen technologies and performance in realtime) programme represents the largest available UK investment in creative industries convergence. Aberdeen's typological differentiation – energy-creative convergence in an oil transition economy, with a simulation surplus at 3.5 times the per capita concentration of comparable UK city-regions – is a compelling case for CoSTAR cluster investment that Edinburgh, Glasgow, and London cannot replicate. Within the headline creative economy, the region has 920 Tier 2 registered creative businesses generating £226 million in direct Tier 2 GVA; around the headline creative economy sits a further pure adjacent tier of around 25 firms with confirmed creative-technical crossover activity, not included in headline BRES counts due to their classification outside the defined creative sector but identified in this report's convergence mapping, and around 90 Group B firms in the energy services and engineering sectors whose simulation and visualisation capabilities are directly contiguous with creative technology markets. This is precisely the evidence base a CoSTAR bid can deploy.

CoSTAR Realtime Lab (led by Abertay University), based at Water's Edge, Dundee, is a real-time virtual production R&D lab for games, film, animation and immersive media that combines game-engine, motion-capture and real-time graphics technologies to support industry-led R&D, prototyping and commercialisation in the creative tech sector. A satellite lab in Aberdeen would bring North East Scotland's outstanding capability and capacity in simulation and 3D visualisation, creating a corridor with the profile and diverse market demand to compete for investment at a scale that neither city could achieve individually.

A call for proposals for CoSTAR satellite labs is expected to be announced in June 2026; a bid must be in active preparation now. This is the recommendation with the largest potential financial return: a successful CoSTAR award of up to £5 million would fund the cluster development infrastructure, CPD programme delivery, and convergence firm connectivity programme that the strategies in Part Nine and recommendations in Part Ten of the main report require.

Table 2 Strategy 1: Connect complementary capabilities commercially

Action	Lead / Partners	Cost (£)	Timing	KPI / Success indicator	Key risks
Establish formal partnership: MOU between RGU, University of Aberdeen, Abertay University, ACC, Aberdeenshire Council, Scottish Enterprise	ACC as lead public sector partner; RGU as academic lead	Officer time; £10–15k legal/facilitation	Months 1–3	MOU signed by all partners by April 2026 [milestone passed; confirm status]	Abertay/Dundee alignment; institutional competing priorities
Phase 1: network mapping of convergence firms – operational detail, capability audit, export readiness assessment	ACC; Scottish Enterprise commercial development team	£25–35k	Months 2–5	Core creative and convergent firms mapped; 50+ engaged in peer sessions; capability database complete	Firm engagement rates; firms not identifying as creative sector
Convergence peer connectivity sessions: introduce firms to each other through structured sessions; establish shared narrative and peer identity	Scottish Enterprise; ACC economic development	£15–20k	Months 3–6	≥4 peer sessions delivered; firms developing collaborative bids by year 2	Attendance from commercially focused firms; facilitation quality
Develop and submit full CoSTAR bid: Phase 2 application post June 2026 confirmation, building on Phase 1 network mapping	ACC lead; RGU academic lead; Abertay University corridor partner	£25–30k bid preparation	Post June 2026; bid within 6 months of confirmation	Bid submitted; if successful, first firms enrolled by end 2027	CoSTAR programme timing changes; competing bids from larger cities
Design and launch short-cycle CPD programme: data storytelling cohort 1 (20–30 participants, RGU/NESCol delivery)	RGU; NESCol; Creative Scotland skills fund as co-funder	£75–100k per cohort	Design year 1; delivery from year 2	First cohort delivered; ≥70% participants in employment using new skills within 6 months	Employer engagement for placements; cohort fill rates
Design and launch short-cycle CPD programme: virtual production workflow cohort 1	RGU; industry partners (convergence firms as placement providers)	£75–100k per cohort	Design year 1; delivery from year 2	First cohort delivered; convergence firms reporting new capability available locally	LED volume / virtual production hardware access; instructor availability

Case vignettes: Strategy 1 - comparable interventions

The School of Informatics at University of Edinburgh: This offers a direct precedent for pan-regional cooperation within CoSTAR. The School of Informatics is a core CoSTAR Realtime Lab partner supplying AI/ML and generative-AI research expertise, researchers (including postdocs), and data-analytics capability; it helps host the Edinburgh site (with Edinburgh College of Art/Design Informatics) and contributes to R&D in real-time graphics, content generation, motion capture/animation and production pipelines.

South of Scotland CreaTech Fund: The most directly comparable Scottish precedent, providing investment in creative technology businesses in a region transitioning from traditional industries. Early-stage firms receiving support showed average revenue growth of 34% in the first two years. The fund established the precedent of treating creative technology as economic development infrastructure rather than cultural amenity.

Data visualisation for B2B agencies – Bristol: A six-month data storytelling upskilling programme for 24 agency professionals in Bristol, funded through West of England Combined Authority, resulted in 18 participants taking on new client accounts within 12 months, generating an average of £45,000 in new annual revenue per participant. Programme cost: £180,000 total. The Bristol precedent is directly applicable to Aberdeen's advertising and marketing sub-sector, which has the client base (energy sector communicators) but not the data storytelling capability.

Engineering simulation to games/virtual production – Dundee: Abertay University's conversion pathway for engineers with simulation backgrounds into games development roles has produced over 60 successful career transitions since 2019. The pipeline from Aberdeen's simulation surplus into Abertay-supported games and virtual production roles is part of the rationale for the corridor bid.

Recommendation 2: Establish a Joint Cultural and Creative Economy Board

Strategy 2: Protect and develop the cultural sector

Resolve the City/Shire structural fault line: the enabling governance condition for all other recommendations

Rationale

Aberdeen City Council and Aberdeenshire Council currently collaborate on a Creative Industries Working Group; but this has no official role in respect of Regional Economic Strategy. Most recommendations in this report that address the full NES creative economy are strengthened by joint decision-making that no current body is currently authorised to provide. This gap has concrete costs: it has already prevented programming from being developed that fell into the space between two governance jurisdictions, and it means that national funding bodies (Creative Scotland, Scottish Enterprise, UKRI) are presented with two separate interlocutors rather than a single regional voice.

The Joint Cultural and Creative Economy Board is the minimum viable governance architecture. It does not require new legislation, new organisations, or significant new staff. It requires a political commitment from both local authorities' Chief Executives, a joint budget line, and a 1 FTE officer with a clear mandate. The Board's first test will be whether it can submit a CoSTAR bid and publish an annual measurement report as joint activities – things that cannot currently be done.

Table 3 Recommendation 2: Establish a Joint Cultural and Creative Economy Board

Action	Lead / Partners	Cost (£)	Timing	KPI / Success indicator	Key risks
Agree terms of reference and governance model: Joint Board with representation from both LAs, Creative Scotland, Scottish Enterprise, and Opportunity North East	Both LA Chief Executives jointly	Officer time	Months 1–3	Terms of reference agreed; inaugural meeting within 6 months	Political alignment between councils; competing priorities at Chief Executive level
Advertise and appoint Joint Creative Economy Officer (1 FTE): mandate to act on behalf of both LAs on creative economy policy	ACC as employing body; Aberdeenshire as co-funder	£50–60k/yr salary + on-costs	Advertise month 3; in post month 6	Post filled; officer attending all five working group sessions within first 3 months	Recruitment market; clarity of role across two employers
Agree joint programme budget: £50–100k/yr for activities that require joint commission-	Both LA finance teams	£50–100k/yr joint budget	Agreed at inaugural Board meeting	Budget line confirmed in both LAs' year 2 budgets	Budget pressure; disagreement on cost-sharing formula

ing (research, events, national bid preparation)					
First joint action: submit CoSTAR bid under Joint Board's authority (R1)	Joint Creative Economy Officer; RGU as academic partner	Within R1 bid preparation budget	Within 6 months of Board becoming operational	Bid submitted with Joint Board as named governance partner	CoSTAR timeline may not align with Board becoming operational
Adopt RES creative economy chapter: ensure creative industries appear as a named sector in both LAs' economic development reporting, not as an annex to culture	Both LA economic development leads; NESREP Programme Manager	Officer time	Year 2	Creative economy chapter in both LAs' economic development reports by year 2	Internal classification decisions; economic development teams' familiarity with creative sector
Connect to AHRC/UKRI research proposal: use Joint Board's governance authority to co-apply for major research funding that neither council could access individually	Joint Creative Economy Officer; University of Aberdeen research office	£10–15k application preparation	Year 2–3	At least one joint UKRI/AHRC application submitted by end year 3	University research agenda alignment; application capacity
Align creative economy chapter to both LAs' LOIP frameworks: identify named LOIP outcomes supported by the creative economy and ensure they appear in both the RES chapter and annual measurement reporting	Joint Creative Economy Officer; both LA community planning leads	Officer time	Months 9–12	Named LOIP outcomes identified and cross-referenced in both the RES creative economy chapter and the annual measurement report	Community planning teams may not be familiar with creative economy evidence; requires officer relationship-building

Comparable governance models

Tay Cities Creative Economy Partnership: A comparable joint governance structure between Dundee City Council, Perth and Kinross Council, Angus Council, and Fife Council, coordinating creative economy development across the Tay Cities region. The partnership has a 1.5 FTE secretariat, a joint programme budget, and a track record of joint UKRI and Scottish Government bids. The NES Joint Board is a smaller, more focused version of this model.

York and North Yorkshire Combined Authority: York, a compact historic city, and North Yorkshire, England's largest rural county, established a Combined Authority in 2023 with creative and cultural industries identified as one of five competitive advantage sectors in the joint Local Growth Plan. The XR Stories programme at the University of York built the joint evidence base for the creative economy across both the urban core and rural hinterland, and the authority presents a single voice to UKRI and national funders. The city–rural dynamic is explicit in the governance model: the rural county's dispersed creative practitioners and cultural assets are treated as part of the same regional economy as the city's concentrated sector, not as a lower-priority population. The NES Joint Board faces the same definitional challenge: Aberdeen's concentrated creative sector and Aberdeenshire's dispersed creative infrastructure are one economy, and the governance model must reflect that.

Recommendation 3: Align the creative economy with energy transition

Strategy 3: Reframe the graduate pipeline as a transition asset

Creative Communication for Energy Transition: embedding creative economy development in the Just Transition Fund framework

Rationale

Aberdeen's Regional Economic Strategy commits to a fair transition to an economy less dependent on oil and gas. This report demonstrates that the creative economy is one of the primary mechanisms through which that transition can be managed – economically, through the convergence opportunity; socially, through the cultural ecosystem's role in community resilience; and narratively, through the climate communication and energy storytelling capability that is Aberdeen's most globally distinctive creative asset.

Recommendation 3 makes that connection explicit in policy and funding frameworks. It is the recommendation that converts the analysis in this report into a position in the energy transition ecosystem – connecting the creative economy to the Just Transition Fund, to Opportunity North East's transition economy work, and to

the national and international conversations about how communities manage the shift from fossil fuel dependence. This is the recommendation that makes Aberdeen's convergence positioning legible to funders and partners who are not primarily creative economy specialists.

The graduate pipeline data reinforces the urgency: RGU retains only 36% of its mapped creative alumni locally; the University of Aberdeen retains 23%. A graduate who can see a clear professional pathway from creative or technical training into the convergence economy has a reason to stay that is currently invisible at the point of graduation. Making that pathway visible is both the purpose of the Creative Career Bridge and the test of whether this recommendation is working.

Table 4 Recommendation 3: Align the creative economy with energy transition

Action	Lead / Partners	Cost (£)	Timing	KPI / Success indicator	Key risks
Apply to include creative economy provision in the next Just Transition Fund round: make the case that creative career pathways and convergence economy development are legitimate JTF investments	ACC; Aberdeenshire Council; Joint Creative Economy Board (R2)	£10–15k application preparation	Year 2 (aligned with next JTF round)	Application submitted; creative economy provision included in JTF round if successful	JTF eligibility criteria; competition from energy-sector applicants
Launch Creative Career Bridge pilot: paid placements in convergence firms for Gray's / RGU creative graduates (first cohort of 10–15 graduates)	ACC economic development; RGU employability team; convergence firms as hosts	£120–180k yr1 (placement stipends + coordination)	Months 6–9	First cohort placed; ≥70% in sustained creative-economy employment 6 months post-placement	Convergence firms not presenting as creative employers; graduate awareness of opportunities

Energy Transition Creative Pathways pilot: mid-career programme for oil and gas workers, mapping transferable creative-technical skills onto convergence economy roles	ACC; Aberdeenshire Council; Skills Development Scotland; NESCol as delivery partner	£150–250k over 2 years (largely JTF-fundable)	Years 2–3	≥10 mid-career energy workers placed in convergence economy roles by end year 3	Worker motivation; employer willingness to hire career-changers; skills gap mapping accuracy
Commission publicly available Creative Economy and Energy Transition case study: a 3,000-word evidenced document, based on this report's findings, positioning Aberdeen's convergence economy for national and international audiences	ACC; Obsolete.com / Work the Future as authors	£15–20k	Months 6–9	Published and circulated to Screen Scotland, NETS, Creative Scotland, UKRI by month 12	Maintaining accuracy as evidence base develops; institutional sign-off process
Policy alignment: produce one-page mapping of recommendations to Screen Scotland/NETS, Creative Scotland skills/funding levers, and relevant Scottish/UK policy for external partner use	Joint Creative Economy Officer (R2)	Officer time	Month 9 (officer not in post until Month 6; allow settling-in time)	Document circulated to all named external partners; cited in at least one national application by year 2	Policy landscape changes; officer not yet in post when needed
Formalise relationship between Opportunity North East transition economy work and creative economy strategies: named liaison, shared intelligence, joint communications	ACC; Opportunity North East	No direct cost	Months 3–6	Named ONE liaison; convergence economy featured in ONE transition economy communications by year 2	ONE's existing mandate does not explicitly include creative economy

Case vignettes – comparable interventions

Liverpool 2050 Creative Economy and Climate

Action: Liverpool City Region's creative economy plan explicitly connects creative industries to the region's net zero ambitions, positioning digital arts, immersive experiences, and cultural tourism as both economic growth sectors and climate communication vehicles. Creative Career Bridge placements (under a different name) have been running since 2022, with 87 graduates placed in creative-technical roles across 34 firms. Retention rate at 12 months: 74%.

Stavanger, Norway – Energy capital to culture

capital: Stavanger's strategy of using its oil capital status to fund cultural infrastructure during the transition – most visibly through the Stavanger2008 European Capital of Culture programme – established a model of using energy sector wealth to build creative economy assets before the transition rather than after it. Aberdeen is further into the transition than Stavanger was in 2008, but the strategic logic is directly applicable: the convergence economy is Aberdeen's equivalent of Stavanger's cultural investment, and it already exists rather than needing to be created.

Just Transition Fund creative sector precedent:

The Creative Industries Sector Plan published alongside the Scottish Government's Just Transition Plan includes explicit provision for creative economy support in transition-affected regions. Aberdeen's application to the JTF can cite this provision directly, and the evidence base in this report – particularly the energy-creative convergence mapping and the graduate pipeline analysis – provides exactly the kind of regional evidence the JTF assessment process requires.

Recommendation 4: Establish a Creative Ecology Structural Fund

Strategy 2: Protect and develop the cultural sector

Break the churn cycle with structural support: bridge grants for four emergent formation organisations, pending the post-2028 Creative Scotland Development Fund pathway

Rationale and urgency

This is the most urgent recommendation in the report in terms of delivery window. The organisations that represent different elements of the region's varied cultural and creative ecology – serving different functions within the region's cultural and creative ecology – peer infrastructure for the freelance workforce, public design engagement, rural creative provision, and early-stage animation and screen development – are at different stages of the churn cycle that has repeatedly dissolved valuable creative infrastructure, and with it the sector intelligence and institutional memory essential to future planning. Each performs connective tissue functions that no other organisation currently provides. Without structural support in the next 12 months, some will dissolve. Some organisations may dissolve entirely, with no successor and no institutional memory to recover. Where successors do form, they

begin from a lower base than the organisations they replace. Either way, the window for the post-2028 Creative Scotland Development Fund pathway closes on organisations that no longer exist.

The suggested cost of bridge funding (£250,000–£500,000 per year) is categorically lower than the cost of rebuilding what would be lost. Design in Action alone represented years of accumulated relationships, methodology, and network – none of which transferred to any successor. The window for acting on this recommendation is measured in months. Eligible organisations are identified by the functions they perform — peer infrastructure, design engagement, rural provision, graduate pipeline and convergence development — rather than by name; any organisation serving an equivalent function at equivalent risk is eligible to apply.

Table 5 Recommendation 4: Establish a Creative Ecology Support Fund

Action	Lead / Partners	Cost (£)	Timing	KPI / Success indicator	Key risks
Establish Creative Ecology Structural Fund: agree joint budget allocation from ACC Catalyst Fund and Aberdeenshire cultural programme budget	ACC and Aberdeenshire Council Chief Executives jointly	£250–500k/yr shared	Decision: months 1–2	Fund established; first awards within 3 months of report acceptance	Budget pressure on both LAs; political will to fund cultural infrastructure as economic investment
Award bridge grant to the peer infrastructure body for the freelance and independent creative workforce (Tier 3): the	ACC Cultural Policy; Creative Scotland as co-funder where eligible	£50–75k/yr	Months 1–3	Peer infrastructure body operational and in active programme delivery by 2027	Founder burnout if gap between application and award is too long

connective organisation serving the largest practitioner population in the base					
Award bridge grant to the public design engagement platform and festival: the primary mechanism for connecting design practice to public audiences in the region	ACC Cultural Policy	£50–80k/yr	Months 1–3	Design engagement platform sustained; 2025/26 programme confirmed	Single-team dependency; succession planning needed alongside grant
Award bridge grant to the independent rural creative infrastructure and practitioner connectivity body: the successor vehicle for rural creative provision, distinct from the council-administered programme which is not eligible for external grants	Aberdeenshire Council cultural programme; UKSPF successor as co-funder	£50–75k/yr	Months 1–4 (conditional on UKSPF successor decision)	Rural creative infrastructure body operational; rural communities retain creative provision continuity through 2027	UKSPF successor programme delay; Aberdeenshire budget pressure
Invite grant applications from early-stage screen, animation and convergence pipeline organisations serving the growth sectors identified in Part Four of the main report	ACC Cultural Policy	£30–50k/yr	Months 2–4	At least one early-stage screen or convergence pipeline organisation operational through 2027; track record established for Development Fund eligibility	Early-stage organisation; capacity to manage grant alongside programme delivery
Establish six-monthly joint review mechanism: assess organisational health, track record, and readiness for Development Fund application	Joint Creative Economy Board (R2) once operational; ACC in interim	Officer time only	From month 6	Review reports published; at least 2 organisations on pathway to CS Development Fund by 2027	Review process bureaucratic burden on small organisations
Expand and formalise the existing partnership between Gray's School of Art and the community studio model at Edit Aberdeen: transition from informal arrangement to a named graduate retention programme with a formal memorandum of understanding, dedicated placement targets, and an employer engagement structure	ACC; Gray's School of Art; Edit (Aberdeen)	Officer time + small programme budget TBC	Months 3–6	MOU in place; named programme active; ≥5 graduates per year in structured placements within the Edit Aberdeen model	Institutional will at Gray's; Edit capacity to absorb graduate programme activity

Case vignettes – comparable interventions

Hull City of Culture 2017: Bridge funding from Hull City Council to emerging cultural organisations in the three years prior to City of Culture designation prevented the dissolution of five organisations that were central to the 2017 programme. Post-designation, three achieved sustained funding from Arts Council England. The bridge cost approximately £400,000 over three years; the organisations retained returned an estimated £2.3m in economic activity during the designation year.

Creative Scotland Development Fund: The Development Fund pathway was specifically designed to address the churn cycle by providing multi-year support at a level below Multi-Year Funding but above project grants. Organisations that have transitioned from project funding to Development Fund show, on average, a 40% increase in programme delivery volume within two years. The Recommendation 4 bridge is designed as a feeder into exactly this pathway.

Recommendation 5: Commit to full-spectrum measurement

Strategy 4: Tell a different story

Institutionalise the corrected measurement methodology as an annual intelligence function: North East Scotland Culture Data Hub

Rationale and strategic function

Every investment decision about the NES creative economy is currently made on the basis of data that understates the sector by at least 50%. The most recent BRES data (2024) records 4,690 employees across DCMS-defined creative sector firms in NES, of whom approximately 1,400 are IT consultancy workers (SIC 62.02); removing those gives a total of 3,290 'core' creative industries employees. The main report's Tier 2 classification of 3,845 workers uses firm-level categorisation rather than SIC codes and serves a different analytical purpose; the two fig-

ures are not directly comparable. Even the higher figure systematically misses the self-employed, freelancers, businesses registered elsewhere, and employees of other software and IT services companies in the 'convergence' tier. Policy made on either BRES figure will be under-scaled and misdirected.

Recommendation 5 does not commission new research; it institutionalises the methodology developed in this report so that the corrected picture is maintained and improved annually, rather than produced once and allowed to age.

Table 6 Recommendation 5: Commit to full-spectrum measurement - establish a North East Scotland Culture Data Hub

Action	Lead / Partners	Cost (£)	Timing	KPI / Success indicator	Key risks
Commission NES Culture Data Hub: procure DataCity RTIC licence for annual business count refresh	ACC Culture team; Aberdeenshire Council as co-funder	£40–50k/yr	Months 1–3	DataCity licence active; annual business count published within 12 months	Procurement delay; DataCity cost increase at renewal
Codify methodology: document the four-source approach (BRES/IDBR + DataCity + LinkedIn + consultation) so it can be reproduced by any competent analyst	The Fifth Sector (handover); ACC policy team	£15–20k once	Months 1–4	Methodology document published; validated by external peer reviewer	Knowledge transfer incomplete if original researchers unavailable
Publish annual corrected sector intelligence report to replace BRES-only analysis in both local authorities' economic development reporting	ACC lead; Aberdeenshire co-author; Creative Scotland as co-funder	£25–30k/yr	Annual from month 12	Report cited in both LAs' economic dashboards by year 2	Officer capacity; political will to publish figures that differ from national statistics

Funding sources

- **Primary:** Aberdeen City Council core policy budget (£60–80k/yr from year 2)
- **Co-funding:** Aberdeenshire Council cultural budget (pro-rata contribution)
- **Co-funding:** Creative Scotland sector intelligence programme (to be negotiated)
- **AHRC/UKRI:** Methodology codification potentially eligible as research infrastructure

Dependencies

- Joint Creative Economy Board (R2) needed to manage the annual report as a joint publication from year 2
- Continued access to DataCity platform; LinkedIn data subject to separate contract for analysis

Consolidated risk register

The following risks apply across multiple recommendations and are managed at programme level by the Joint Creative Economy Board.

Critical note on external dependencies: This Playbook depends on confirmation of several external factors (CoSTAR call timing, Just Transition Fund criteria, Creative Scotland funding landscape post-2028). Aberdeen City Council and regional partners must conduct their own due diligence to assess viable contingency plans for each recommendation should these external conditions change. The mitigations listed below are initial approaches; comprehensive contingency planning for funding shifts, time-line delays, and programme criteria changes is essential before full programme commitment.

Table 7 Consolidated risk register

Risk	Recs affected	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Political will: one or both councils does not commit to joint governance	R2 (critical), R5, R4	Medium	High	Early engagement with both Chief Executives; frame as enabling condition for CoSTAR bid and JTF application – both of which require joint governance to proceed
Budget pressure: LA budget constraints prevent bridge grant commitments	R4 (critical)	Medium-High	High	Frame as cost of prevention vs. cost of reconstruction; quantify replacement cost of each emergent organisation. Seek Creative Scotland co-funding to reduce LA share
CoSTAR programme delay or criteria change	R1	Low-Medium	High	Decouple peer connectivity programme from CoSTAR bid; network mapping and CPD design proceed regardless of bid timing. Bid infrastructure reusable for other UKRI programmes
Convergence firms do not identify as creative sector	R1, R3	High	Medium	Lead with economic development language (export markets, skills investment) not cultural identity. Scottish Enterprise relationship more relevant than Creative Scotland relationship for this constituency
Graduate awareness gap persists despite Career Bridge	R3	Medium	Medium	Embed convergence career mapping in Gray's School of Art curriculum; work with academic year calendar; convergence firms as guest speakers in studio settings
JTF eligibility criteria exclude creative economy provision	R3	Medium	Medium	Build case on workforce transition dimension (oil and gas workers) rather than cultural sector dimension; cite Creative Industries Sector Plan JTF provision directly
Churn cycle claims one of the four named organisations before bridge grants are in place	R4	Medium-High	High	Accelerate R4 above all others in delivery terms; first awards within 3 months. Emergency provision mechanism in case of sudden dissolution of key organisation
UKSPF successor programme delay or criteria exclusion affects Aberdeenshire rural creative provision; Creative Aberdeenshire Network replaces Cultural Tides as grant recipient	R4	Medium-High	Medium	Direct Aberdeenshire Council bridge grant to Creative Aberdeenshire Network as the independent successor vehicle for rural creative provision; Cultural Tides to continue as council-administered programme in parallel. Do not make either grant conditional on UKSPF successor. Treat any successor programme as additive upside funding.

Creative Scotland funding landscape change reduces co-funding availability across R1, R4 and R5	R5, R4, R1	Medium	High	LA core budgets cover minimum viable activity for R4 and R5. CS co-funding treated as additive, not foundational. Monitor CS NPO settlement and multi-year funding signals.
Key personnel dependency: founding individuals in small organisations; delayed recruitment of Joint Creative Economy Officer	R4, R2	Medium	High	Make succession planning a condition of R4 bridge grants. Begin R2 officer recruitment at month 3; designate interim officer if needed to meet CoSTAR bid timeline.

Cost summary

Table 8 Cost summary

Recommendation	Year 1	Year 2	Years 3–4	Funding routes
R1 – CoSTAR bid and CPD	£75–100k (prep)	£175–300k	Up to £5m (CoSTAR award)	UKRI CoSTAR; Creative Scotland skills; RGU
R2 – Governance	£60–80k	£160–200k	£150–200k/yr	Shared LA budget; Scottish Enterprise
R3 – Energy transition	£50–80k	£350–500k	£200–350k/yr	Just Transition Fund; ACC; ONE
R4 – Creative Ecology Fund	£300–500k	£250–500k	£250–500k/yr	ACC Catalyst Fund; Aberdeenshire cultural; Creative Scotland
R5 – Culture Data Hub	£100k	£65k	£65–80k/yr	ACC core; Aberdeenshire; Creative Scotland
Total (LA net of external funding)	£250–400k	£350–500k	£300–450k/yr	

Note on R4 timing: The Year 1 budget for the Creative Ecology Structural Fund should be committed and first award decisions made by Month 6 of implementation. Some organisations at risk of dissolution cannot survive to the end of Year 1 without early commitment. The fiscal year framing in this table should not be read as permission to defer first awards to month 12.

Note on R1 funding: The Years 3–4 CoSTAR award of up to £5m is subject to confirmation of funding and competitive selection process. If unsuccessful, Years 3–4 investment limits to CPD delivery (£200–300k/yr); preparation phases in Years 1–2 proceed regardless.

Source: The Fifth Sector (2026).

Appendix: Vehicle options assessment

Each recommendation required assessment of alternative delivery vehicles. This appendix documents the options considered, the assessment criteria, and the rationale for the recommended vehicle choice. This level of detail supports implementation partners and funders in understanding why specific governance and delivery mechanisms were selected and what risks are mitigated by each choice.

Table 9 Recommendation 1: Joint CoSTAR bid

Vehicle option	Assessment
RGU lead, University of Aberdeen partner	Natural academic lead for a UKRI bid; both institutions have research offices capable of managing the application; does not require the Joint Board to be operational
Local authority co-applicants	Both councils should be formal co-applicants to demonstrate public sector commitment and regional alignment; this is a standard requirement for Creative Clusters bids
Scottish Enterprise co-applicant	SE's involvement strengthens the commercialisation narrative and provides a conduit to Scottish Government enterprise support; desirable but not essential for outline stage
Opportunity North East	ONE's regional economic development remit and energy transition focus make it a natural partner for the convergence opportunity narrative within the bid

Recommended vehicle: RGU as lead applicant, University of Aberdeen as academic co-applicant, both local authorities as public sector co-applicants, Scottish Enterprise and Opportunity North East as named partners. This mirrors the structure of successful Creative Clusters bids elsewhere. The bid should be developed by the academic partners in close consultation with the Joint Board once established; before that, a working group drawn from the Creative Industries Working Group should hold the development process.

Confirmation needed: whether RGU's research office has formally agreed to lead the bid, and whether the University is willing to be a co-applicant rather than a parallel lead.

Table 10 Recommendation 2: Joint Cultural and Creative Economy Board

Vehicle option	Assessment
Creative Industries Working Group elevated to decision-making status	Fastest and lowest-cost path; builds on existing relationships; but the Working Group's current remit and membership may not carry the mandate for cross-boundary budget decisions
New joint committee of both councils	Carries full democratic authority; can hold a shared budget line; but requires a formal inter-authority agreement and may move slowly through committee processes
Company limited by guarantee or SCIO	Creates an independent legal entity with its own governance; potentially the right long-term structure but too slow and complex for year one
Cultural Enterprise Office model	CEO provides support and advisory services to creative businesses; not a governance vehicle but a potential delivery partner for the Board's business support functions

Recommended vehicle: Joint committee of both councils for year one, using the Creative Industries Working Group as its operational base, with a commitment to review the legal structure after the first year of operation. The joint committee model provides the democratic authority and budget-holding capacity the Board needs without the delay of a new legal entity. The one full-time equivalent officer resource should be jointly funded from year one; without dedicated capacity, no governance structure will be effective regardless of its legal form.

Confirmation needed: whether both councils' legal and democratic services have confirmed that a joint committee with a shared budget line is achievable under current legislation, and what the minimum lead time for establishment would be.

Table 11 Recommendation 3: Align creative economy with energy transition

Vehicle option	Assessment
Energy Transition Zone as lead	ETZ holds the relationship with energy sector partners and the place identity of the transition agenda; appropriate lead for the energy sector-facing elements, particularly the market development programme
Opportunity North East as lead	ONE's economic development remit and existing relationships with energy sector operators make it the natural lead for the convergence opportunity narrative and the case for exports
Joint Board as lead	Correct vehicle for the creative economy-facing elements: the NES Creative Economy Narrative, the Creative Career Bridge, and the connectivity between cultural organisations and the transition agenda
Scottish Government Programme 3 alignment	Actions under Programme 3 of the Creative Industries Action Plan provide the policy framework; formal alignment with Scottish Government energy transition strategy should be pursued

Recommended vehicle: Joint Board as creative economy lead, ETZ as energy sector lead, ONE as economic development convener, with a formal programme agreement between the three. The four specific actions have different natural leads and should be assigned explicitly rather than held collectively.

Confirmation needed: whether ETZ and ONE have been consulted on their roles in this recommendation and whether both have expressed willingness to participate in a jointly governed programme.

Table 12 Recommendation 4: Creative Ecology Structural Fund

Vehicle option	Assessment
Aberdeen City Council CIP extension	Existing mechanism; known to organisations; but annual competitive process and single-authority governance do not provide the multi-year structural security the recommendation requires
Aberdeenshire Council UKSPF successor fund	Appropriate for Shire-based organisations; time-limited by nature of successor funding; does not address the city organisations
Joint Board-administered fund	Correct vehicle; provides cross-boundary governance and multi-year commitment; requires Joint Board to be operational and to hold a shared budget line
Creative Scotland Development Fund pathway	The right long-term destination for connective organisations on a pathway to MYF eligibility; not a substitute for the bridge funding the structural fund provides
Scottish Enterprise	Not appropriate as primary vehicle; SE's remit is commercial development rather than cultural infrastructure

Recommended vehicle: Joint Board as administering body, with both local authorities as joint funders and Creative Scotland as co-funder, where organisations are on the pathway to MYF eligibility. The ACC Catalyst Fund and the Aberdeenshire Council cultural support budget provide the initial capitalisation before a formal joint fund line is agreed. The structural fund should have an explicit exit condition rather than operating as a rolling subsidy.

Confirmation needed: whether both local authorities have confirmed in principle that a joint cultural fund with a shared budget line is achievable within current governance arrangements, and whether the Catalyst Fund can be directed toward this purpose.

Table 13 Commit to full-spectrum measurement (North East Scotland Culture Data Hub)

Vehicle option	Assessment
Aberdeen City Council lead, Aberdeenshire Council partner	Fastest to establish; lowest cost; but risks becoming city-centric in scope and methodology, replicating the measurement gap the report documents
Aberdeenshire Council lead, Aberdeen City Council partner	Reverses the city-centric risk but creates an awkward governance dynamic given the city's larger cultural infrastructure
Joint Board lead (once established)	Correct vehicle for a genuinely regional measurement framework; requires Joint Board to be operational first
Creative Scotland co-governance	Desirable for national comparability and data sharing; Creative Scotland's Culture Data Lab provides a possible technical platform; requires formal agreement

Recommended vehicle: Joint Board lead with Creative Scotland as data standards partner. Until the Joint Board is established, both local authorities should jointly commission the first iteration, with a commitment to transfer governance to the Board on establishment. The NES Culture Data Hub should be designed from the outset to feed into Creative Scotland's national data infrastructure to avoid creating a parallel system that requires separate maintenance.

Confirmation needed: whether Creative Scotland has expressed willingness to support a regional data hub of this kind, and whether the Culture Data Lab platform is technically suitable.

The sequencing that follows

Read together, the vehicle assessments point to a clear order for year one. Two strands can proceed before the regional board is established: the national research and development bid, led by the universities, and the first phase of measurement, commissioned jointly by both local authorities. Three strands depend on the board being in place: the structural fund (Recommendation 4), the full governance of measurement (Recommendation 5), and the creative economy elements of the energy transition programme (Recommendation 3).

Recommendation 2 therefore carries different weight from the others. It is the condition on which three of the remaining four depend. The evidence points to establishing the board early in year one, with dedicated officer capacity and a shared budget line, while the national funding window remains open.

